

KEY TOPIC 1 COURSE TEXTBOOK • CHRONOLOGICAL ENQUIRY SEQUENCE • 1945–1956**THE CREATION OF THE STATE OF ISRAEL***From Imperial Mandate and UN Partition to the 1948 War and the 1956 Suez Crisis***ARCHIVAL PRIMARY RECORD • 14 MAY 1948****GPO-ARCHIVE / ACC-1948-05-14****Proclamation of the State of Israel, Tel Aviv Museum of Art**

David Ben-Gurion reading the Declaration of Independence beneath the portrait of Zionist visionary Theodor Herzl, 14 May 1948 (Rudi Weissenstein).

ARCHIVAL PRIMARY RECORD

EDEXCEL PAPER 2 MASTER ARCHIVE

PEARSON EDEXCEL GCSE (9–1) HISTORY SPECIFICATION CONTENT**KEY TOPIC 1 COVERAGE****1.1 CREATION OF ISRAEL, 1945–48**

- Conflicting post-WWII interests: Jewish immigration vs Arab national self-determination.
- Armed Jewish insurgency: Haganah, **Irgun** & **Lehi**; bombing of **King David Hotel** (**July 1946**).
- British exhaustion: 100,000 troops deployed, post-war debts, and the **SS Exodus affair** (**July 1947**).
- Referral to UN: UNSCOP commission & **UN Resolution 181 Partition Plan** (Nov 1947).
- Outbreak of sectarian communal civil war following UN partition announcement.

1.2 THE 1948–49 WAR & REFUGEES

- British Mandate terminates; Ben-Gurion proclaims **State of Israel** (14 May 1948).
- Immediate Arab invasion by five neighboring armies; initial Israeli defensive crisis.
- Turning points: First UN Truce (June 1948), **Czech arms resupply** & IDF unification.
- **1949 Armistice agreements (Green Line)**: Israeli territory expands from 56% to 78%.
- **Palestinian refugee crisis (Nakba)**: 700,000 displaced; UNRWA & 1950 Law of Return.

1.3 THE SUEZ CRISIS, 1955–63

- Rise of **Gamal Abdel Nasser**, Pan-Arabism, Gaza Raid & Czech arms deal (1955).
- US cancels Aswan Dam loans; Nasser announces **nationalisation of Suez Canal** (July 1956).
- Secret tripartite collusion: Anglo-French-Israeli invasion across Sinai & Port Said.
- Superpower intervention: US financial pressure halts invasion; UN emergency ceasefire.
- Humiliating British/French withdrawal, deployment of **UNEF peacekeepers** in Sinai.

CAUSAL CHAIN OF EVENTS**CHRONOLOGY**

- 1917** Balfour Declaration: Jewish Homeland
- Jul 1946** King David Hotel Bombing (Irgun)
- Feb 1947** Britain Refers Mandate to the UN
- Nov 1947** UN Resolution 181: Partition Plan
- Apr 1948** Deir Yassin & Sectarian Civil War

CAUSAL CHAIN OF EVENTS**CHRONOLOGY**

- 14 May 48** Ben-Gurion Declares State of Israel
- 15 May 48** Five Arab Armies Invade Palestine
- Jun 1948** First UN Truce: Czech Arms & IDF
- Oct 1948** Operation Yoav Breaks Negev Siege
- 1949** Green Line Armistice: Nakba Exodus

CAUSAL CHAIN OF EVENTS**CHRONOLOGY**

- Feb 1955** Gaza Raid Exposes Egyptian Weakness
- Sep 1955** Egyptian-Czech Arms Agreement
- 26 Jul 56** Nasser Nationalises Suez Canal
- 24 Oct 56** Secret Sèvres Collusion Protocol
- Nov 1956** Sinai Invasion; US Halts Blitz & UNEF

KEY TOPIC 1.1 HISTORICAL FOUNDATIONS • 1915-1945

Broken Promises & Imperial Borders: Why Was Conflict Inevitable?

Pearson Specification Focus: Conflicting interests and demands of Jews and Arabs within the British Mandate; the McMahon-Hussein Correspondence (1915), the secret Sykes-Picot Agreement (1916), the Balfour Declaration (1917), and the 1939 British White Paper.

The Ottoman Collapse & The First World War

[1.1] For over four centuries leading up to 1914, the Middle East was administered as regional provinces of the Turkish **Ottoman Empire**. The local population was overwhelmingly Arab, comprising both Muslim and Christian communities who had lived alongside ancient, indigenous Jewish communities in Jerusalem, Safed, Tiberias, and Hebron. There were no national borders dividing Lebanon, Syria, Jordan, or Iraq; the geographic area historically referred to as Palestine was governed under Ottoman sanjaks.

[1.2] When the Ottoman Empire entered World War One on the side of Imperial Germany in October 1914, Great Britain faced a grave strategic crisis. The Ottoman Sultan declared a holy jihad against Allied forces, threatening Britain's vital imperial lifeline: the **Suez Canal**, through which Indian troops, Australian grain, and Persian oil flowed to the Western Front. To undermine Turkish power from within, British military intelligence in Cairo actively sought an alliance with Arab tribal leaders.

Contradictory Wartime Pledges: McMahon vs. Sykes-Picot

[1.3] Between July 1915 and March 1916, Sir Henry McMahon, British High Commissioner in Egypt, exchanged ten critical letters with Sharif Hussein of Mecca. In return for an armed Arab revolt against Ottoman garrisons, McMahon promised British recognition of an independent Arab state across the Arabian Peninsula and the Levant. However, McMahon inserted ambiguous geographic exemptions regarding territories "lying to the west of the districts of Damascus, Homs, Hama and Aleppo." While Arabs firmly believed Palestine was included in the promised independent realm, British officials later claimed Palestine lay west of Damascus and was deliberately excluded.

[1.4] Simultaneously and in absolute secrecy, British diplomat Sir Mark Sykes and French representative François Georges-Picot drafted the **Sykes-Picot Agreement (May 1916)**. Disregarding McMahon's pledges, Britain and France drew an arbitrary line across the map: France claimed direct control of modern Lebanon and Syria, while Britain claimed Iraq and Transjordan. Crucially, Palestine was designated for international administration to safeguard religious shrines. When Bolshevik revolutionaries leaked the secret treaty in November 1917, Arab leaders were enraged by what they regarded as imperial duplicity.

SOURCE A

HISTORICAL MAP

May 1916

The Secret Sykes-Picot Carve-Up of the Middle East

"France and Great Britain are prepared to recognize and protect an independent Arab State or a Confederation of Arab States... subject to French direct rule along the Syrian coast and British direct rule in southern Mesopotamia."

Anglo-French Secret Diplomatic Agreement

16 May 1916

SOURCE B

ARCHIVAL PHOTOGRAPH

11 December 1917

General Allenby Enters Jerusalem on Foot via the Jaffa Gate

General Sir Edmund Allenby enters the Holy City on foot out of religious respect, formally ending four centuries of Ottoman Turkish rule and establishing British military administration across Palestine.

Imperial War Museum
Archive

Jerusalem Operations, 11 December 1917 (Q 12616)

KEY SPECIFICATION TERMINOLOGY & CONCEPTS			DISCIPLINARY VOCABULARY
Zionism: Movement founded by Theodor Herzl (1897) advocating for a sovereign Jewish national	McMahon-Hussein (1915): British letters promising an independent Arab state in exchange for an armed revolt	Sykes-Picot (1916): Secret Anglo-French treaty partitioning the Middle East into British and French imperial	

The Balfour Declaration & Zionist Aspirations

[1.5] On 2 November 1917, British Foreign Secretary Arthur Balfour issued a historic 67-word public letter to Lord Walter Rothschild, a prominent leader of the British Jewish community. The **Balfour Declaration** stated that His Majesty's Government viewed with favour "the establishment in Palestine of a national home for the Jewish people," while adding the safeguard that "nothing shall be done which may prejudice the civil and religious rights of existing non-Jewish communities in Palestine."

[1.6] The declaration was driven by a mixture of strategic and political motives. British Prime Minister David Lloyd George sought to enlist global Jewish sympathy—particularly in revolutionary Russia and the United States—to bolster the Allied war effort. Strategically, British control over Palestine offered an essential buffer safeguarding the Suez Canal. For the Zionist movement, founded by Theodor Herzl in 1897, the declaration provided indispensable diplomatic legitimacy from the world's leading imperial power.

SOURCE C

DIPLOMATIC DOCUMENT

2 November 1917

The Balfour Declaration to Lord Walter Rothschild

Foreign Office,
November 2nd, 1917.

Dear Lord Rothschild,
I have much pleasure in conveying to you, on behalf of His Majesty's Government, the following declaration of sympathy with Jewish Zionist aspirations which has been submitted to, and approved by, the Cabinet.
"His Majesty's Government view with favour the establishment in Palestine of a national home for the Jewish people, and will use their best endeavours to facilitate the achievement of this object, it being clearly understood that nothing shall be done which may prejudice the civil and religious rights of existing non-Jewish communities in Palestine, or the rights and political status enjoyed by Jews in any other country."
I should be grateful if you would bring this declaration to the knowledge of the Zionist Federation.



"His Majesty's Government view with favour the establishment in Palestine of a national home for the Jewish people, and will use their best endeavours to facilitate the achievement of this object..."

Foreign Office Dispatch / Arthur Balfour

The National Archives, Kew (FO 371/3058)

ARCHIVAL DISPATCH

WAR CABINET RECORD

31 October 1917

Balfour Defends the Formula to the War Cabinet

"The vast majority of Jews in Russia and America appear to be favourably disposed to Zionism... If we could make a declaration favourable to such an ideal, we should be able to carry out extremely useful propaganda in both countries. Furthermore, it establishes a strategic buffer adjacent to the vital maritime corridor of the Suez Canal."

British War Cabinet Minutes (CAB/23/4)

10 Downing Street, 31 October 1917

The Mandate Era & The 1939 British White Paper

[1.7] In 1922, the League of Nations formalized Britain's administrative rule as the **Mandate for Palestine**, explicitly incorporating the Balfour Declaration into international law. Between 1922 and 1939, waves of Jewish immigration (Aliyah), fleeing rising antisemitism and Nazi persecution in Europe, transformed the demographic landscape. The Jewish population increased from roughly 11% in 1922 to nearly 30% by 1939. Land purchases by the Jewish National Fund led to evictions of Palestinian tenant farmers, sparking severe inter-communal riots in 1929 and the nationwide **Arab Revolt (1936–1939)**.

[1.8] To suppress the rebellion, Britain deployed 25,000 troops and instituted harsh emergency regulations. In 1937, the Peel Commission recommended partition for the first time, but both communities rejected it. With World War Two looming and Britain desperately needing Arab oil and stability across the Middle East, the British government issued the **May 1939 White Paper**. It capped Jewish immigration at 75,000 over five years, restricted land transfers to Jews, and promised independence within ten years under majority Arab rule. Zionist leaders viewed the White Paper as a catastrophic betrayal at the very moment European Jewry faced annihilation.

KEY FIGURE

1848–1930



Arthur Balfour
BRITISH FOREIGN SECRETARY (1916–1919)

Authored the 1917 Balfour Declaration, transforming Zionism from a fringe political movement into a legally recognized international project.

STRATEGIC DECISIONS & ACTIONS:

- Secured Imperial Cabinet Support:** Persuaded Lloyd George's War Cabinet to issue a formal British pledge for a Jewish national home.
- Drafted Ambiguous Safeguards:** Inserted protective clauses for existing non-Jewish communities while deliberately refusing to define the borders or governance of the proposed homeland.
- Institutionalised the Mandate:** Championed the incorporation of the Balfour Declaration into the 1922 League of Nations Mandate.

HISTORICAL CONCEPT

DIPLOMATIC AMBIGUITY

The Balfour Formula: 'National Home' vs 'State'

Arthur Balfour and Lloyd George's War Cabinet deliberately selected the unprecedented phrase 'a national home for the Jewish people' rather than 'a Jewish state'. This calculated ambiguity was designed to avoid alarming non-Zionist British Jews and Palestinian Arabs while rallying Jewish wartime support in America and Russia. Simultaneously, it protected British imperial control over the approaches to the Suez Canal. It created an irreconcilable diplomatic contradiction that bedevilled the British administration for thirty years.

Exam Distinction: 'National Home' offered cultural and spiritual refuge without explicitly guaranteeing sovereign statehood or defined territorial boundaries.

KEY TOPIC 1.2 MANDATE COLLAPSE • 1945–1947

The Collapse of the British Mandate & Jewish Insurgency

Pearson Specification Focus: Conflicting interests after World War Two; Jewish insurgency (Irgun and Lehi); the bombing of the King David Hotel (July 1946); British economic and military exhaustion; the SS Exodus affair (1947); and UNSCOP recommendations.

Post-WWII Crisis & The Jewish Insurgency

[2.1] In 1945, the revelation of the Nazi Holocaust, in which six million European Jews were systematically murdered, electrified global opinion. Over 250,000 Jewish survivors languished in Displaced Persons (DP) camps across Germany and Austria, desperate to emigrate to Palestine. However, Britain's new Labour Foreign Secretary, **Ernest Bevin**, stubbornly enforced the 1939 White Paper's quota of just 1,500 immigrants per month, fearing that opening the floodgates would alienate Arab states and jeopardize Middle Eastern oil supplies.

[2.2] Outraged by Bevin's policy, the three Jewish underground militias in Palestine united under the **United Resistance Movement**. While the mainstream **Haganah** focused on organizing illegal immigrant blockade-runners (Aliyah Bet) and sabotaging British radar stations, radical right-wing paramilitary groups—the **Irgun** (led by Menachem Begin) and the **Lehi** (Stern Gang)—launched an aggressive urban guerilla insurgency targeting British soldiers, police officers, and infrastructure.

The King David Hotel Bombing (July 1946)

[2.3] On 22 July 1946, the Irgun struck the heart of the British administration. Disguised as Arab milkmen, Irgun operatives smuggled 350 kilograms of TNT inside milk churns into the basement of the **King David Hotel** in Jerusalem, which housed the British Military Headquarters and Secretariat. The resulting massive explosion demolished the entire southern wing of the six-story stone building, killing 91 people: 28 Britons, 41 Arabs, 17 Jews, and 5 others.

[2.4] The bombing shocked the British public and government. British authorities declared martial law, imposed severe curfews, and enclosed government buildings inside barbed-wire security compounds nicknamed 'Bevingrad.' Over 20,000 British soldiers conducted house-to-house sweeps in Tel Aviv and Jerusalem, detaining thousands of suspects. Yet rather than deterring the insurgents, the harsh security crackdown intensified Jewish popular hostility toward British rule.

The Acre Prison Breakout & The Sergeants Affair (1947)

[2.5] On 4 May 1947, the Irgun executed one of the most audacious insurgent operations of the Mandate era: the **Acre Prison Break**. Disguised as British Royal Engineers, Irgun commandos used explosive gelignite to blow a massive breach through the historic walls of the Crusader fortress at Acre. Amid heavy machine-gun fire and diversionary mortar barrages, 27 Irgun and Lehi commanders escaped, while 214 Arab prisoners also broke out amidst the pandemonium.

[2.6] The British responded with severe military justice, sentencing three captured Irgun operatives—Avshalom Haviv, Meir Nakar, and Yaakov Weiss—to death by hanging. In July 1947, when British authorities executed the three men at Acre, the Irgun carried out its threat of immediate retaliation. Operatives abducted two young British Army Intelligence Corps NCOs, **Sergeants Clifford Martin and Mervyn Paice**, and hanged them in an orange grove near Netanya. When British troops discovered the hanging bodies, a hidden anti-personnel mine detonated, severely wounding a British captain. The **Sergeants Affair** provoked anti-Jewish riots across British cities and destroyed British domestic tolerance for remaining in Palestine.

SOURCE A

ARCHIVAL PHOTOGRAPH

22 July 1946

Ruins of the King David Hotel, Jerusalem



SOURCE B

ARCHIVAL PHOTOGRAPH

July 1947

The Sergeants Affair: Bodies Found Near Netanya



The SS Exodus Affair & British Exhaustion

[2.7] In July 1947, the aging American riverboat **SS Exodus 1947**, packed with 4,514 Holocaust survivors including 655 children, approached the coast of Palestine without immigration visas. Royal Navy destroyers rammed the vessel in international waters, boarded with tear gas and batons, and killed three passengers. Instead of placing the refugees in Mediterranean internment camps on Cyprus as was customary, Foreign Secretary Bevin decided to make a punitive example: he ordered the refugees shipped back to port of departure in France, and when they refused to disembark, forcibly deported them to British-occupied Germany.

[2.8] The spectacle of British soldiers dragging emaciated Holocaust survivors back behind barbed wire in Hamburg triggered a global public relations catastrophe. American newspapers expressed intense outrage, and US President Harry S. Truman exerted severe diplomatic pressure. For a British economy crippled by war debt, rationing, and imperial overstretch, stationing 100,000 troops in Palestine at an annual cost of £40 million had become financially and politically intolerable.

SOURCE C ARCHIVAL PHOTOGRAPH

July 1947

The SS Exodus Arriving in Haifa under Naval Escort



"The spectacle of Holocaust survivors being forced behind barbed wire by British bayonets in Germany destroyed Britain's moral standing and convinced the United Nations that the Mandate had to end."

United Nations Special Committee on Palestine Archive

Haifa Port, 18 July 1947

ARCHIVAL DISPATCH

PARLIAMENTARY STATEMENT

25 February 1947

Ernest Bevin Announces Referral to the UN

"His Majesty's Government have been faced with an irreconcilable conflict of principles. We have decided that we are unable to accept the scheme put forward by either the Arabs or the Jews... and we have resolved to refer the whole problem to the United Nations. We are not going to the United Nations to ask for their advice; we are setting the problem before them so that they may settle it, as Britain can no longer bear this unilateral burden alone."

Hansard Parliamentary Debates

House of Commons, 25 February 1947

UN Referral & The UNSCOP Inquiry

[2.9] By early 1947, Great Britain was gripped by acute economic crisis: severe fuel shortages during the brutal winter of 1946–47, bread rationing at home, and crushing war debts owed to the United States. Stationing 100,000 soldiers in Palestine cost £40 million annually, drawing fierce parliamentary condemnation. Convinced that reconciling Zionist demands for statehood with Arab demands for independence was impossible without open military subjugation, Prime Minister **Clement Attlee** made the momentous decision in February 1947 to surrender Britain's imperial mandate and refer the entire question to the newly created **United Nations**.

[2.10] The UN created the **United Nations Special Committee on Palestine (UNSCOP)**, composed of eleven neutral nations to ensure impartiality. UNSCOP toured the country, witnessed the interception of the SS Exodus in Haifa, and interviewed Jewish Agency leaders. The Arab Higher Committee boycotted the inquiry, arguing that European persecution could not justly be compensated with Arab land. In August 1947, UNSCOP recommended terminating the Mandate and partitioning Palestine into independent Arab and Jewish states with international status for Jerusalem. Britain refused to enforce partition, setting a unilateral evacuation deadline of 15 May 1948.

KEY FIGURE

1883–1967



Clement Attlee
BRITISH PRIME MINISTER (1945–1951)

Labour Prime Minister who ended the British Mandate in Palestine, prioritizing domestic reconstruction over costly imperial policing.

STRATEGIC DECISIONS & ACTIONS:

- **Referred Mandate to the UN:** Recognized in February 1947 that Britain could not satisfy both Jewish and Arab demands without unsustainable military force.
- **Set Hard Evacuation Deadline:** Refused to enforce UN Partition, setting a rigid withdrawal date of 15 May 1948 to minimize British casualties.
- **Withdrew 100,000 British Troops:** Ended British financial drainage (£40M/year) amidst post-war rationing and economic austerity.

HISTORICAL MECHANISM

IMPERIAL EXHAUSTION

The Economic Drain: 100,000 British Troops & Post-War Austerity

Deploying 100,000 soldiers in Palestine cost £40 million annually (£1.8 billion today) amidst the brutal winter freeze of 1946–47, strict bread rationing, and heavy American war debts. Clement Attlee's Cabinet recognized that Britain could no longer sustain costly imperial policing overseas while establishing the National Health Service and Welfare State at home.

Key Causation: Domestic economic exhaustion—not military collapse—forced Britain's historic decision to surrender the Palestine Mandate to the United Nations.

KEY TOPIC 1.3 PARTITION & WAR • 1947–1949

UN Resolution 181 & The 1948–49 Arab–Israeli War

Pearson Specification Focus: UN Resolution 181 (Partition Plan, November 1947); outbreak of civil war; the British evacuation; David Ben-Gurion's declaration of Israel (14 May 1948); invasion by five Arab armies; the UN truces; and the 1949 Armistice Agreements (Green Line).

UN Resolution 181 & The Outbreak of Civil War

[3.1] On 29 November 1947, the UN General Assembly voted 33 to 13 (with 10 abstentions, including Great Britain) to adopt **Resolution 181**, partitioning Palestine into two independent states. The proposed Jewish state received 56% of the territory—including the fertile coastal plain, the eastern Galilee, and the arid Negev Desert—even though Jews constituted roughly 33% of the total population and owned approximately 7% of the land. The proposed Arab state received 43% of the land, while Jerusalem and Bethlehem were designated a *Corpus Separatum* under UN international administration.

[3.2] Jewish leaders, headed by David Ben-Gurion, accepted partition as an indispensable international recognition of statehood, despite misgivings over borders. Arab leaders and the Arab Higher Committee rejected it outright, condemning it as an illegitimate imposition that violated self-determination. The day after the vote, violence erupted as Arab snipers ambushed Jewish buses near Petah Tikva, igniting a vicious six-month **civil war**. Both sides fought for control of roads and strategic villages, while British forces passively withdrew to coastal enclaves. In April 1948, the Haganah launched **Plan Dalet**, an offensive aimed at securing supply corridors to besieged Jewish Jerusalem.

The Declaration of Independence & Arab Invasion

[3.3] On Friday afternoon, 14 May 1948, hours before the British Mandate officially expired at midnight, David Ben-Gurion read the **Declaration of the Establishment of the State of Israel** at the Tel Aviv Museum of Art. Within hours, US President Harry Truman granted de facto recognition, followed swiftly by the Soviet Union.

[3.4] On the morning of 15 May 1948, regular military forces from five Arab states—**Egypt, Transjordan, Syria, Iraq, and Lebanon**—invaded Palestine. The Arab League declared their goal was to liberate Palestine and establish a unitary Arab state. In the initial weeks, the Arab forces held substantial superiority in heavy artillery, armored vehicles, and airpower. Egyptian columns advanced within 20 miles of Tel Aviv, while the British-officered Arab Legion of Transjordan seized East Jerusalem, driving Jewish defenders from the Old City.

SOURCE A

HISTORICAL MAP

November 1947

The UN Partition Plan (Resolution 181)



"Independent Arab and Jewish States and the Special International Regime for the City of Jerusalem shall come into existence two months after evacuation of the armed forces of the mandatory Power."

United Nations General Assembly

Resolution 181 (II), 29 November 1947

SOURCE B

MILITARY CAMPAIGN MAP

May–October 1948

The 1948 Arab Invasions & Frontline Offensives



Coordinated five-nation Arab offensive launched on 15 May 1948, showing axes of advance across northern Galilee, central Jerusalem, and southern coastal approaches towards Tel Aviv.

IDF Historical Branch Records

1948 War Archive

KEY SPECIFICATION TERMINOLOGY & CONCEPTS			DISCIPLINARY VOCABULARY
UN Resolution 181 (1947): UN General Assembly partition plan allocating 56% of Mandatory Palestine to create an independent Jewish state.	Haganah & The IDF: The primary Jewish defense militia, officially consolidated into the national Israel Defense Forces on 26 May 1948.	The Green Line (1949): Armistice demarcation boundaries signed on Rhodes, leaving Israel in control of 78% of the former British Mandate.	

The First UN Truce & The Czech Arms Resupply

[3.5] The turning point came during the **First UN Truce (11 June – 8 July 1948)**, negotiated by UN mediator Count Folke Bernadotte. While both sides were theoretically barred from importing weapons or reinforcements, Israel exploited the four-week lull with extraordinary efficiency. Jewish agents finalized a secret weapons pipeline with **Czechoslovakia** (authorized by Stalin), secretly airlifting tens of thousands of Mauser rifles, machine guns, artillery, and 25 Avia S-199 fighter aircraft into Israel (Operation Balak).

[3.6] Israel reorganized its competing underground militias into a single, disciplined national military: the **Israel Defense Forces (IDF)**. To eliminate rival commands, Prime Minister David Ben-Gurion ruthlessly enforced state authority. When the Irgun attempted to land an independent cargo of heavy weaponry aboard the transport ship *Altalena* on Tel Aviv beach in June 1948, Ben-Gurion ordered the IDF to shell the vessel, killing sixteen Irgun fighters and forcing Menachem Begin to disband his forces completely. Israeli troop numbers surged from 30,000 in May to 65,000 by July and over 100,000 by December. In contrast, the five invading Arab armies were crippled by severe political rivalries, non-existent communication, and mutual distrust between King Abdullah of Jordan and the Egyptian monarchy.

SOURCE C

ARCHIVAL PHOTOGRAPH

14 May 1948

David Ben-Gurion Proclaims the State of Israel



"We hereby declare the establishment of a Jewish state in Eretz-Israel, to be known as the State of Israel." Proclamation read at the Tel Aviv Museum beneath Theodor Herzl's portrait on 14 May 1948.

Israel Government Press Office (GPO)

Independence Hall, Tel Aviv (14 May 1948)

IDF Counter-Offensives & The 1949 Armistice

[3.7] When fighting resumed during the 'Ten Days' of July 1948, the reinforced IDF launched sweeping counter-offensives. Operation Dani captured Lydda and Ramle; Operation Yoav broke the Egyptian blockade of the Negev; and Operation Hiram cleared northern Galilee. In September 1948, Jewish extremist paramilitaries from the **Lehi (Stern Gang)** assassinated UN Mediator Count Folke Bernadotte in Jerusalem after he proposed revising the partition borders and repatriating Arab refugees. The murder shocked world opinion and prompted Ben-Gurion to outlaw Lehi permanently. American diplomat **Ralph Bunche** stepped in to lead the United Nations peace mission.

[3.8] Between February and July 1949, Bunche presided over protracted bilateral negotiations on the Greek island of Rhodes, resulting in separate **Armistice Agreements** between Israel and Egypt, Lebanon, Jordan, and Syria. The resulting ceasefire boundaries, universally known as the **Green Line**, left Israel in control of 78% of Mandatory Palestine—nearly a third more territory than proposed under UN Resolution 181. Transjordan occupied and subsequently annexed the West Bank and East Jerusalem, while Egypt retained military administration of the Gaza Strip. Crucially, Arab states refused to sign permanent peace treaties or recognize Israel's legal sovereignty, ensuring the border remained a volatile military frontline.

KEY FIGURE

1886–1973



David Ben-Gurion

FIRST PRIME MINISTER OF ISRAEL (1948–1963)

Founding father of the State of Israel who proclaimed independence and unified underground militias into the IDF during the 1948 War.

STRATEGIC DECISIONS & ACTIONS:

- **Proclaimed Independence:** Declared the State of Israel on 14 May 1948 despite intense US State Department pressure to delay.
- **Created Unified Military (IDF):** Disbanded underground paramilitaries (Irgun, Lehi, Palmach) into a single national army, ordering the shelling of the Irgun arms ship *Altalena*.
- **Secured Czech Arms Pipeline:** Authorized emergency funding for Czechoslovakian aircraft and rifles during the critical first UN truce.

HISTORICAL CRISIS

STATE SOVEREIGNTY • JUNE 1948

The Altalena Affair: Enforcing the State's Monopoly on Force

When the Irgun attempted to land arms aboard the transport ship *Altalena* on Tel Aviv beach during the first truce, Ben-Gurion ordered the newly formed IDF to shell the vessel. Sixteen Irgun fighters died, but Ben-Gurion decisively established that no independent private militias would be tolerated within the new sovereign state.

Key Significance: Established undisputed civilian authority over the armed forces, preventing civil war.

KEY TOPIC 1.4 AFTERMATH OF 1948 • 1948–1954

The Palestinian Refugee Crisis (Nakba) & The Green Line

Pearson Specification Focus: The Palestinian refugee problem (Nakba): causes, scale, and conditions in refugee camps; UN Resolution 194; the establishment of UNRWA; the 1949 Armistice Agreements (Green Line); and Israel's Law of Return.

The 1948 Palestinian Exodus (The Nakba)

[4.1] During the 1948–49 War, between 700,000 and 750,000 Palestinian Arabs—over 80% of the Arab population living within what became the borders of Israel—fled or were expelled from their towns and villages. Palestinians refer to this catastrophe as the **Nakba**. Over 400 Arab villages were depopulated, abandoned, and subsequently demolished or re-inhabited by incoming Jewish immigrants.

[4.2] Historians identify multiple, interrelated causes for the flight. In the early phases, the collapse of Palestinian urban leadership and the flight of wealthy elites created widespread panic among poorer villagers. Panic turned to terror following the massacre of over 100 Arab villagers at **Deir Yassin** by Irgun and Lehi fighters in April 1948, reports of which were amplified by Arab radio broadcasts to rally resistance, but instead accelerated civilian flight. In later phases, the IDF carried out deliberate expulsions under Plan Dalet to secure military axes, most notably the forced expulsion of 50,000 residents from Lydda and Ramle in July 1948.

Refugee Camps, UNRWA & UN Resolution 194

[4.3] The displaced Palestinians fled into neighboring Arab regions: approximately 280,000 to the West Bank, 200,000 to the Gaza Strip, 100,000 to Lebanon, 75,000 to Syria, and 70,000 to Transjordan. The vast majority ended up in squalid, overcrowded tent cities. In December 1948, the UN passed **Resolution 194**, resolving that refugees wishing to return to their homes and live at peace should be permitted to do so at the earliest practicable date, and compensation should be paid for lost property.

[4.4] Israel adamantly refused the return of refugees, arguing that repatriating hundreds of thousands of hostile Arabs would constitute national suicide and that Arab states bore responsibility for invading. In December 1949, the UN created the **United Nations Relief and Works Agency (UNRWA)** to provide basic food rations, healthcare, and education to the refugees. Except for Jordan, which granted citizenship, Arab host states refused to integrate refugees permanently, insisting they maintain refugee status to preserve their collective right of return.

SOURCE A ARCHIVAL PHOTOGRAPH

1948

Palestinian Refugees Fleeing Their Homes during the 1948 War



Over 700,000 Palestinian refugees were displaced into camps in Gaza, the West Bank, Lebanon, Syria, and Jordan, transforming the demographic balance of the region.

UNRWA Historical Archive

1948 Nakba Record

SOURCE B ARCHIVAL PHOTOGRAPH

1949–1950

Displaced Families at an UNRWA Tent Camp



Makeshift canvas tents in an emergency UNRWA refugee camp. Over 700,000 Palestinians faced severe overcrowding, winter storms, and reliance on emergency food rations across Gaza and the West Bank.

UNRWA Photographic Archive

Refugee Relief Record, 1949–1950

KEY SPECIFICATION TERMINOLOGY & CONCEPTS

DISCIPLINARY VOCABULARY

The Nakba (Catastrophe):

The expulsion and flight of over 700,000 Palestinian Arabs from their ancestral homes during the 1948 War.

Law of Return (1950):

Fundamental Israeli legislation granting every Jewish individual worldwide the legal right to immigrate and gain citizenship.

Fedayeen Guerrillas:

Palestinian nationalist irregulars conducting armed infiltration, sabotage, and mine raids across the armistice frontiers.

The 1949 Armistice Borders & Infiltration

[4.5] The bilateral armistice lines negotiated at Rhodes were drawn with green pencil on military maps, becoming universally known as the **Green Line**. Crucially, Arab delegates insisted that these demarcations were solely temporary military ceasefire boundaries rather than permanent international borders, as they refused to confer de jure recognition upon Israel. Israel, in turn, treated the Green Line as its provisional sovereign frontier, fortifying border outposts.

[4.6] The Green Line created severe friction on the ground. Villages were severed from their farming lands, wells, and ancestral cemeteries. In the early 1950s, thousands of destitute Palestinian refugees crossed the armistice lines back into Israel. While most were unarmed peasants seeking to harvest crops or retrieve belongings, armed Palestinian militants—known as **fedayeen** ('self-sacrificers')—carried out sabotage and guerrilla attacks against Israeli border settlements. Israel responded with an aggressive reprisal policy: for every attack, the IDF launched punitive, cross-border strikes against host villages, creating a continuous cycle of border escalation.

The Law of Return & Mass Jewish Ingathering

[4.7] While adamantly refusing the repatriation of Palestinian Arab refugees, the Israeli Knesset enacted the foundational **Law of Return (5 July 1950)**. The landmark statute declared that every Jewish person across the global diaspora possessed an inalienable, ancestral right to immigrate to Israel and claim immediate, automatic citizenship. Over the subsequent four years, Israel's Jewish population more than doubled, soaring from approximately 650,000 in May 1948 to over 1.5 million by 1953.

[4.8] This demographic transformation occurred through two major waves: first, approximately 300,000 European Holocaust survivors from DP camps; second, over 600,000 **Mizrahi Jews** fleeing rising persecution, anti-Zionist riots, and state-sponsored expulsions across the Arab world (including ancient Jewish communities in Iraq, Yemen, Morocco, Libya, and Egypt). To absorb the massive influx, Israel established emergency transit camps (*ma'abarot*) of tin huts and canvas tents, gradually building new development towns along vulnerable frontiers. This mass ingathering cemented Israel's Jewish demographic majority but deepened the bitter rift with the Arab world, where Palestinians saw Jewish immigrants occupying their requisitioned ancestral homes.

SOURCE C

HISTORICAL MAP

1949 Armistice

The 1949 Armistice Agreements & The Green Line

"The 1949 Armistice Lines (Green Line) expanded Israel's territory to 78% of Mandatory Palestine. The West Bank was incorporated into Jordan, while the Gaza Strip fell under Egyptian military administration."

United Nations Armistice Commission

Rhodes Agreements Record (1949)

KEY FIGURE

1935–1999

King Hussein of Jordan

KING OF JORDAN (1952–1999)

Monarch who ruled Jordan and the annexed West Bank, managing the largest population of Palestinian refugees in the Middle East.

STRATEGIC DECISIONS & ACTIONS:

- Integrated Palestinian Refugees:** Granted full Jordanian citizenship to hundreds of thousands of displaced Palestinians across the West Bank and East Bank.
- Maintained Custodianship of Holy Sites:** Preserved Jordan's historic custodianship over Muslim and Christian holy places in Jerusalem (Haram al-Sharif / Temple Mount).
- Managed Border Clashes:** Struggled to control cross-border fedayeen raids while facing massive Israeli military reprisal strikes (such as Qibya in 1953 and Samu in 1966).

ARCHIVAL DISPATCH

LEGISLATIVE ENACTMENT

5 July 1950

The Law of Return Enacted by the Israeli Knesset

"Every Jew has the right to come to this country as an *oleh* (immigrant)... An immigrant's visa shall be granted to every Jew who has expressed his desire to settle in Israel, unless the Minister of Immigration is satisfied that the applicant is acting against the Jewish people." Enacted on 5 July 1950, doubling Israel's Jewish population within three years.

Knesset Parliamentary Records

Laws of the State of Israel (Vol. 4, 1950)

HISTORICAL REALITY

DISPLACEMENT & SETTLEMENT

UNRWA & The Refugee Camps: From Canvas to Concrete

Established by UN Resolution 302 in December 1949, UNRWA provided emergency shelter, healthcare, and food rations to over 700,000 displaced Palestinians. What were intended as temporary tent encampments gradually hardened into permanent concrete cinderblock townships across Gaza, the West Bank, Jordan, Syria, and Lebanon. Host nations, except Jordan, denied full citizenship to keep the collective 'Right of Return' alive, cementing generations of Palestinians in stateless refugee camps.

Disciplinary Insight: Camp permanence institutionalized the refugee crisis as the enduring moral and territorial core of the conflict.

KEY TOPIC 1.5 SUPERPOWER CRISIS • 1955–1963

Increased Tension, Nasser, and the 1956 Suez Crisis

Pearson Specification Focus: The rise of Gamal Abdel Nasser and Pan-Arabism; the 1955 Czech arms deal; the Aswan High Dam; nationalisation of the Suez Canal (July 1956); the secret Protocol of Sèvres; the Suez War; and the humiliating withdrawal of Britain and France.

The Rise of Nasser & The Czech Arms Deal (1955)

[5.1] In July 1952, a group of nationalist Egyptian army officers called the **Free Officers** overthrew King Farouk in a bloodless coup. By 1954, **Gamal Abdel Nasser** emerged as President of Egypt. Charismatic and fiercely anti-colonial, Nasser championed **Pan-Arabism**—the belief that the Arab world should unite to throw off Western imperial domination and confront Israel. Nasser stepped up support for Palestinian fedayeen operating out of the Gaza Strip and blocked Israeli shipping through the **Straits of Tiran** (the entrance to the Gulf of Aqaba) and the Suez Canal.

[5.2] In February 1955, after an Israeli reprisal raid in Gaza killed 38 Egyptian soldiers, Nasser sought modern weapons. Rebuffed by the United States, Nasser stunned the West in September 1955 by signing the **Egyptian-Czech Arms Deal**. In exchange for Egyptian cotton, the Soviet bloc supplied Egypt with 200 MiG-15 fighter jets, 300 tanks, and submarines. This shattered Western arms monopolies in the Middle East, shifted the military balance against Israel, and brought Cold War superpower rivalry directly into the region.

The Aswan Dam & Nationalisation of the Canal

[5.3] Nasser's flagship modernization project was the **Aswan High Dam**, intended to control the Nile's annual floods and generate hydroelectricity for Egyptian industrialization. In July 1956, angered by Nasser's recognition of Communist China and arms deals with Moscow, US Secretary of State John Foster Dulles abruptly cancelled \$70 million in American funding, followed swiftly by Britain and the World Bank.

[5.4] On 26 July 1956, in a dramatic radio speech in Alexandria, Nasser delivered a secret code-word: *de Lesseps* (the French engineer who built the canal). At that signal, Egyptian troops seized the headquarters of the Anglo-French **Suez Canal Company**. Nasser announced the canal was nationalized and that transit toll revenues would fund the construction of the Aswan Dam. While Arab populations celebrated wildly, British Prime Minister **Anthony Eden** viewed Nasser as an expansionist dictator—a "Mussolini on the Nile"—who threatened Britain's imperial oil route and prestige.

SOURCE A ARCHIVAL NEWSPAPER

27 July 1956

Al-Ahram Front Page: Suez Canal Nationalised



"President Nasser announces from Alexandria: 'The Suez Canal Company has been nationalized in the name of the Egyptian nation! The canal was dug by Egyptian blood; its revenues belong to Egypt!'"

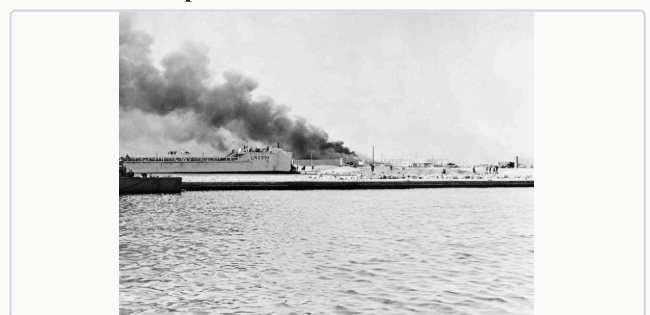
Al-Ahram Daily (Cairo)

Friday, 27 July 1956

SOURCE B ARCHIVAL PHOTOGRAPH

November 1956

British Paratroopers & Centurion Tanks at Port Said



British paratroopers and Centurion tanks of the Royal Tank Regiment advance through the war-damaged streets of Port Said during Operation Musketeer, shortly before the UN-enforced ceasefire.

Imperial War Museum Archive

Suez Landings, Port Said (MH 31737)

KEY SPECIFICATION TERMINOLOGY & CONCEPTS

Canal Nationalisation:

Nasser's seizure of the Anglo-French Suez Canal Company in July 1956 following Western cancellation of Aswan Dam loans.

Protocol of Sèvres:

Secret tripartite collusion pact signed by Britain, France, and Israel in October 1956 to invade Egypt and depose Nasser.

DISCIPLINARY VOCABULARY

UNEF Peacekeepers:

The United Nations Emergency Force, deployed as a neutral buffer across Sinai to monitor the tripartite military withdrawal.

The Secret Protocol of Sèvres & Military Operation

[5.5] Determined to overthrow Nasser, Britain and France held secret talks with Israel at a private villa in Sèvres, outside Paris, in October 1956. Together they concocted the **Protocol of Sèvres**: Israel would launch a surprise invasion across the Sinai Desert towards the Suez Canal; Britain and France would then pose as impartial peacekeepers, issuing an ultimatum demanding both Egypt and Israel withdraw 10 miles from the canal; when Nasser inevitably refused to evacuate his own territory, Anglo-French forces would intervene militarily to "separate the combatants" and seize the canal.

[5.6] On 29 October 1956, Israel launched **Operation Kadesh**. Israeli paratroopers dropped near the Mitla Pass, while armored columns swept across Sinai, routing Egyptian garrisons and reaching the canal within 100 hours. On 30 October, London and Paris issued their pre-planned ultimatum. When Egypt rejected it, British and French bombers destroyed the Egyptian Air Force on the ground, and on 5 November, Allied paratroopers and marine commandos landed at **Port Said** (Operation Musketeer).

SOURCE C MILITARY CAMPAIGN MAP October–November 1956

Operation Kadesh & The Anglo-French Assault on Port Said

Israeli forces seized the Sinai Peninsula in 100 hours while Anglo-French amphibious forces secured the northern entrance to the Suez Canal before international intervention forced a halt.

War Office Historical Summary Port Said Operation Musketeer, 1956

ARCHIVAL DISPATCH PRESIDENTIAL ULTIMATUM 6 November 1956

President Eisenhower's Sterling Ultimatum to Eden

President Dwight D. Eisenhower blocked IMF emergency loans and threatened to dump US holdings of the British pound sterling unless Eden ordered an immediate ceasefire in Egypt within 24 hours. Facing currency collapse with reserves plunging \$50 million daily and unable to finance food and fuel imports, Downing Street was forced into an unconditional capitulation.

US Department of State Diplomatic Files Foreign Relations of the United States (1956)

The Superpower Ultimatum & British Humiliation

[5.7] The military triumph was swiftly converted into an absolute diplomatic disaster. US President **Dwight D. Eisenhower** was furious that Britain and France had colluded behind his back on the eve of the US presidential election, distracting the world from the Soviet invasion of Hungary. Refusing to support the operation, Eisenhower threatened to destroy the British economy by blocking International Monetary Fund (IMF) loans and dumping US holdings of British sterling unless Allied forces immediately ceased fire. Soviet Premier Nikolai Bulganin went further, threatening rocket attacks on London and Paris.

[5.8] Facing financial collapse, Eden ordered an immediate ceasefire on 6 November. By December, British and French troops made a humiliating withdrawal from Egypt, followed by Israeli withdrawal from Sinai in March 1957. The consequences were profound: Britain was stripped of its status as an independent global superpower; Anthony Eden resigned in disgrace in January 1957; the United Nations deployed its first peacekeeping force (**UNEF**) along the Egypt-Israel border; and Nasser, despite military defeat, emerged as an untouchable hero of anti-colonial resistance across the Arab world.

KEY FIGURE 1897–1977

Anthony Eden
BRITISH PRIME MINISTER (1955–1957)

Prime Minister whose secret collusion in the 1956 Suez Crisis ended in international humiliation, shattering British imperial prestige.

STRATEGIC DECISIONS & ACTIONS:

- Concluded Protocol of Sèvres: Authorized the secret tripartite plan with France and Israel to seize the Suez Canal and overthrow Nasser.
- Miscalculated US Reaction: Erroneously assumed Eisenhower would remain neutral or support Britain against Soviet encroachment.
- Resigned in Disgrace: Capitulated to US financial pressure, suffering total political collapse and resigning as Prime Minister in January 1957.

HISTORICAL MECHANISM DIPLOMATIC COLLUSION

The Protocol of Sèvres: Collusion & Imperial Rupture

Drafted in secrecy at a private villa outside Paris on 24 October 1956, the Protocol of Sèvres bound Britain, France, and Israel in an artificial conspiracy. Israel would attack Egypt; Britain and France would intervene as 'neutral peacekeepers' to separate the combatants and seize the canal. Prime Minister Anthony Eden ordered all British copies burned to hide the conspiracy, dreading international condemnation and legal prosecution under the UN Charter.

Exam Significance: Exposed the total collapse of 19th-century imperial gunboat diplomacy in a post-WWII world governed by superpowers and the UN.

KEY TOPIC 1: CHRONOLOGY & DISCIPLINARY MASTERY (1915–1956)

Comprehensive revision index of foundational turning points, diplomatic agreements, and Edexcel examination question frameworks.

KEY TOPIC 1 MASTER TIMELINE • CRITICAL CHRONOLOGICAL SEQUENCE

1915–1916	McMahon-Hussein Letters	Britain promises Sharif Hussein an independent Arab kingdom in exchange for an armed revolt against the Ottoman Empire.
May 1916	Sykes-Picot Agreement	Secret Anglo-French deal partitioning the Middle East into British and French imperial spheres of influence.
2 Nov 1917	Balfour Declaration	British Foreign Secretary pledges British support for a 'national home for the Jewish people' in Palestine.
May 1939	British White Paper	Caps Jewish immigration at 75,000 over 5 years and limits land sales, infuriating Zionists on the eve of the Holocaust.
22 Jul 1946	King David Hotel Bombing	Irgun detonates explosives in British HQ in Jerusalem, killing 91 administrative and military personnel.
Jul 1947	SS Exodus Affair	Royal Navy intercepts 4,500 Holocaust survivors and ships them back to Germany, creating global public outcry against Britain.
29 Nov 1947	UN Resolution 181	UN General Assembly votes 33–13 to partition Palestine into Jewish and Arab states; immediate civil war breaks out.
14 May 1948	Creation of State of Israel	David Ben-Gurion proclaims independence in Tel Aviv; British Mandate terminates at midnight.
15 May 1948	Invasion of Five Arab Armies	Egypt, Transjordan, Syria, Iraq, and Lebanon invade; Israeli counter-offensives and Czech arms secure victory.
1949	Armistice Agreements (Green Line)	Ceasefire lines leave Israel in control of 78% of Palestine; West Bank annexed by Jordan, Gaza held by Egypt.
26 Jul 1956	Nationalisation of Suez Canal	Nasser nationalises the Anglo-French canal company following US withdrawal of funding for the Aswan Dam.
Oct–Nov 1956	The Suez Crisis & US Intervention	Protocol of Sèvres collusion; Israeli Sinai blitz & Anglo-French invasion of Port Said halted by US financial threats.

KEY DISCIPLINARY TERMINOLOGY

- **Mandate:** Legal trustee authorization under the League of Nations for Britain to administer Palestine.
- **Nakba:** Arabic for 'catastrophe'; the mass displacement of over 700,000 Palestinian Arabs during the 1948 War.
- **Green Line:** The 1949 armistice demarcation boundary separating Israel from Jordan's West Bank and Egyptian Gaza.
- **Law of Return (1950):** Israeli legislation granting every Jewish individual worldwide the legal right to immigrate to Israel.
- **Protocol of Sèvres:** Secret tripartite collusion pact between Britain, France, and Israel in October 1956 to invade Egypt.
- **UNEF:** United Nations Emergency Force deployed in Sinai to maintain buffer between Egypt and Israel after Suez.

EDEXCEL PAPER 2 EXAM FRAMEWORK & MODELS**32 MARKS
TOTAL****Q1: Explain ONE consequence of... [4 Marks]***Model Question:* "Explain one consequence of the bombing of the King David Hotel in July 1946."*Formula:* Trigger → Destruction of HQ → Hardening of British resolve to evacuate. (1 paragraph)**Q2: Write an analytical narrative explaining... [8 Marks]***Model Question:* "Write an analytical narrative explaining the outbreak of the Suez Crisis (1956). You may use: (1) Czech Arms Deal (1955), (2) Suez Nationalisation."*Formula:* 3 chronological stages linked with causal connectives ('Consequently', 'As a direct result').**Q3: Explain the importance of... for... [8 Marks]***Model Question:* "Explain the importance of the SS Exodus affair (1947) for the British decision to hand Palestine to the UN."*Formula:* 2 PEEL paragraphs explaining 'What difference did X make to Y?'**INTERACTIVE DIGITAL RETRIEVAL HUB KEY TOPIC 1 KNOWLEDGE QUIZ & FLASHCARDS**

Scan the QR code with any smartphone or tablet camera to launch the interactive, self-marking retrieval bank for Key Topic 1. Test your rapid recall across the Balfour Declaration, King David Hotel, UN Partition, 1948 War, Palestinian Refugee Crisis (Nakba), and the Suez Crisis with instant model answers and scoring.

- 20 Specification Recall Questions
- Instant Self-Marking & Explanations
- Digital Leitner Flashcard Deck

**SCAN FOR MOBILE QUIZ**